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The Long Afternoon

A novella

Annu

The Long Afternoon
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This is a work of fiction. Names, characters and incidents are the product of the author's imagination.

First edition.

One

The house had decided, in her absence, to become smaller. Rekha noticed it the way you notice a person has cut their hair - not at once, but as a wrongness that takes a moment to name. The corridor was the same corridor. The tiles were the same cold tiles. And yet she had to turn her shoulders to pass the almirah, and she was almost certain she had never had to do that before.

Devi was in the back room with the papers. She had made two piles on the floor, and between them, like a referee, a steel thermos.

"You came," Devi said, not looking up.

"I said I would come."

"You said that in March."

There was no good answer to that, so Rekha sat down on the floor, which she had not done in that room since she was perhaps nineteen, and which her knees now treated as a provocation.

Two

The piles, it turned out, were not organised by year or by importance but by whether Devi had already cried over them. Rekha did not ask this directly. She worked it out from the way her sister handled each sheet, and from the fact that the smaller pile contained the electricity bills.

By the second hour they had developed a rhythm. Devi read out a name; Rekha said keep or throw; neither of them mentioned that they had not once disagreed.

"Mrs. Fernandes," Devi said. "Nineteen eighty-eight. She wants to know if Amma is free on the twelfth."

"Throw."

"She signed it with love."

"Everyone signed everything with love in nineteen eighty-eight. Throw it."

Devi threw it, and then, a moment later, picked it out of the bag again and put it in the smaller pile, and Rekha said nothing at all.

Three

The envelope was at the bottom of the trunk, under a folded sari that nobody had worn and nobody had been able to give away. It was addressed in their mother's hand to both of them, which was the part that made it impossible.

If it had been addressed to Rekha, Devi would have handed it over and left the room, and been generous about it for twenty years. If it had been addressed to Devi, Rekha would have gone to the kitchen and made a show of finding something to do. Addressed to both of them, it required a decision, and they had never once in their lives made one of those together.

They looked at it for a while.

"She wrote this after," Devi said.

"I know when she wrote it."

"Then you know what it says."

"I know what I think it says." Rekha put her hand flat on the floor beside the envelope, not touching it. "That's not the same thing, and I've had twenty years of confusing the two."

Four

The light in that room went orange at about four and stayed that way for an hour, which is why their mother had always done her accounts there, and why neither of them had ever been able to lie in it.

Devi opened the envelope. She did not read it aloud. She read it once to herself, and her face did something complicated, and then she turned it around and held it out so that they could both see it at the same time.

It was four lines long. Three of them were about the tamarind tree.

Rekha laughed before she could stop herself, and once she had started, the sound went somewhere she had not expected, and Devi came and sat beside her on the floor and did not say it was all right, which was the kindest thing available.

Later, in the kitchen, Devi poured out the last of the tea, which had gone cold and was undrinkable, and both of them drank it.